



Security is perhaps the biggest worry of the digital age

of the phone's cost! You'd be better off pawning the phone and buying a later model with the feature set you want—if you can manage to figure out what you want!

Even computers are not spared: Just when you thought you had everything you wanted in a computer, along comes Apple with their enticing iPod, mesmerising you with its coolness, compactness and sound, and before you know it, you're twenty-something thousand rupees in debt on your credit card and have an MP3 player that can store 50 times more songs than you own, or have even heard!

That's still not the problem, however. You get home, unpack your little beauty and think, "Ah, my precious, I can't wait to download my entire collection of MP3s to you!" Easier said than done—"What the hell is this whole FireWire business, where's the damn USB connector?" you hear yourself scream.

Time to upgrade your computer with a FireWire PCI card! There goes another Rs 1,000, and more if you decide to get a card that adds USB 2.0 heads.



Security Snags

Security is perhaps the biggest worry of the digital age. Everyone and their uncle are paranoid about security, and with good reason—what with all the millions

of worms, Trojans, viruses and malicious code floating about in cyberspace. As devices and technologies converge, they increase the risk of creating even bigger security holes in the end product.

Take Bluesnarfing and Bluejacking for instance! It's bad enough that hackers are finding it easier and easier to get into Bluetooth-enabled devices; do we really need to give them access to all our devices? Or for that matter, do we want to put ourselves at additional risk by letting convergence force us to store all our data on just a single exploitable device?

If an older cell phone was hacked, the hacker only got hold of, say, contact numbers and SMSes, but if your smartphone-with-a-camera is hacked, the hacker can get hold of your address book, your pictures, your files, meeting schedules and more. Think Paris Hilton!

Let's not even begin to imagine what a hacker would do with your Bluetooth-enabled laptop—which, incidentally, is Bluetooth-enabled only because you need to transfer data to and from your smart-phone!



Of Standards

There are none! At least that's how it seems when the latest technologies are released, and subsequently incorporated into new gadgets.

It's quite silly that some device manufacturers form small consortiums and test interoperability only between themselves. As a result, when new technologies are released, you get a rush of devices that are only half-tested and released, just to keep up with the first-to-market brand.

As a result, a device made by manufacturer A works with a similar device made by B, but not with devices made by C and D. And, with your

luck, all your friends will buy devices from manufacturers C and D.

So now what? Either you cross your fingers, hope that your manufacturer will release a quick fix (such as a software ROM update/flashing) that will make the devices compatible, or you junk your device and buy one from the same manufacturer as your friends.



On The Blink

Convergence means that you depend on fewer gadgets to help you do more of your daily tasks. But what happens when the device fails, or when you drop it?

As it is, devices aren't made to be even half as sturdy as they used to be; now you have the additional worry of knowing that this one little gadget in your hand is your cell phone, PDA, laptop, MP3 player and more, all together.

Take a smartphone that you use as a cell phone, MP3 player and PDA. If you drop it and the phone display goes kaput, you have to send it for repairs. While the phone is being butchered at the service centre, you're stuck without your PDA contact list, meeting schedule, and even your travel music!

Even with MFDs (Multi-Function Devices), if the scanner unit stops functioning, you have to do without printing, copying and faxes while it's being repaired!



Jack Of All

Manufacturers are so busy trying to offer you a whole range of uses for a single device that they end up compromising on quality.

There is no contest between the quality offered by specialised devices and the quality of converged devices. A standalone scanner will always work faster and better, ditto for a printer; digital cameras will always offer more functions and better picture quality than cell phone cameras. It's the same for all devices.

It's Not All Bad

The point of what we've said here is not that convergence shouldn't happen; it most definitely should. But manufacturers and users alike need to be more discerning about the problems we've mentioned, so as to best avoid wasting their time and our money.

Manufacturers need to test and verify the compatibility of technologies properly, not just with their devices, but also with devices from other brands. This is only possible when brands stick to offering technologies that have proper standards and guidelines in place. Perhaps reaching a standard before launching a product is the solution. But is it possible?

As end users, we also need to be more discerning about what we buy, and think a lot before spending our hard-earned money on the latest gadgets—just because they showcase features that we've never even heard of! We also need to realise that the latest, is not always the best.

Remember, if the buying stops, the manufacturing will too! ☒

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